At an emergency meeting of the Chinese Communist Party's Standing Committee and then the Central Military Commission (CMC) on September 11, Xi reversed his previously cautious course. He ordered the PLAN to block all US ships from coming into China's "historic waters" of the South China Sea, and to either escort out or capture any US vessels remaining in the sea. He also ordered a no-fly zone over the Spratlys and Paracels. Moreover, he promised to target any Japanese naval ships that accompanied US vessels into the South China Sea. However, Xi continued to reject suggestions that US air bases in Japan, or Japanese air bases, immediately be targeted with ballistic missiles, a decision that caused deep resentment within the PLA.

China's Choice to Expand the War

Nonetheless, Xi's decision to confront US forces and essentially turn a skirmish into a war has been hotly debated by historians. Without access to the papers of the Standing Committee or CMC, and with diplomatic and academic ties between China and the United States severely curtailed after the war, it is largely guesswork as to why Xi chose the path he did. Some analysts point to the weakness of the Chinese economy, which had resulted in growing public dissatisfaction for several years, and surmise that the war was a way to divert public attention. Others argue that shrinking military budgets, which were used by China's political adversaries in Asia to claim that its days as the most powerful Asian military were drawing to a close, caused fear among China's top leadership that their military strength was a wasting asset. Many, however, argue that Beijing's grand strategy had been clear for years, underscoring Xi's belligerent rhetoric stretching back to the 2010s and his assertion that Taiwan would be absorbed into China, as evidence that he was waiting for an opportunity to give a black eye to an America he believed was unwilling to put up a major fight.[41]

Whatever the actual reason, it seems clear that Chinese leaders, above all Xi, realized they had just a few days to try to stake out a dominant position before US Navy vessels began reaching the